The support for such extremists resulted in more sectarian violence within the country. The majority of the students in this study believed that the military and its war were not to blame for sectarianism. Yet there were others who questioned the security state: '*Look at the Sipha e Sahaba. They openly say that Shias are not Muslims and can be killed. This happens openly in Pakistan*' (Focus Group, Private University[14]). These militant outfits have continued to wreak havoc in cities such as Karachi, especially in the 1980s and 1990s when Shia doctors, academics and other prominent members were strategically targeted by these outfits. For some students Pakistan is clearly a proxy for Iran and Saudi Arabia, though such observations are in a minority. However, there is a predominantly Sunni bias as prevalent in other institutions as well, from schools and the curriculum (as discussed in Chapter 3) to, some would argue, even media: '*Also look at the language used by the media. Recently a Shia mosque was attacked in Kuwait. In media they reported it as a "Shia mosque". Over here they call it "Imam bargha" as if Shias can't have a mosque, it has to be called something different. Even the language they use divides us*' (Focus Group, Private University[15]).

The participants were not completely wrong in blaming state policy for exacerbating sectarianism within the country. It was state appeasement of such extremist groups that strengthened their base support. Even the presence of the Taliban was the result of this 'good' versus 'bad' Taliban strategy under the Musharraf era. The valley of Swat was the first to experience direct Taliban rule. At first welcomed by some of the locals, Taliban governance quickly descended into brutality and chaos. The advance of the militants and their success in taking over the valley would have been impossible without the help of the MMA, which was in charge of KP at that time. Mullah Fazlullah used the FM radio stations to propagate his message of jihad against infidels at home and in the West, using this as a conduit to impose Sharia law in Swat. Women were banned from going outside and girls stopped from going to school, music shops were closed, tapes and videos destroyed and men were forbidden to shave. A new parallel court system resolved disputes resulting in public floggings and public executions. It was only in 2009 when the militants advanced to neighbouring Buner district (a five-hour drive from Islamabad) that the authorities decided to take action. The operation between May and July that year displaced almost three million people while many militants simply fled to neighbouring districts or to Afghanistan's Nuristan province bordering PATA to regroup. Others fled to Karachi, a move that would be repeated by many militants in the subsequent